President.[*] Third, Khrushchev's action challenged the President personally. Did he, John F. Kennedy, have the courage in the crunch to start down a path with significant probability of nuclear war? If not, Khrushchev would win this round. More important, he would gain confidence that he could win the next as well—simply by forcing Kennedy to choose between a nuclear path and acquiescense. Kennedy had worried, both after the Bay of Pigs and after his Vienna meeting with Khrushchev, that the Chairman might have misjudged his mettle. This time Kennedy was determined to stand fast. The nonforcible paths—avoiding military measures, resorting instead to diplomacy—could not have been less relevant to *his* problem.

These two paths—"doing nothing" or "taking a diplomatic approach" as the alternatives were labeled in the Ex Comm—were the solutions advocated by two of his principal advisers. For Secretary of Defense McNamara, the missiles raised a specter of nuclear war. He first framed the issue as a straightforward strategic problem. To understand the issue, one had to grasp two obvious but difficult points. First, the missiles in Cuba represented an inevitable occurrence: narrowing of the missile gap between the United States and U.S.S.R. It simply happened sooner rather than later. Second, the United States could accept this occurrence since its consequences were minor: seven to one missile "superiority," one to one missile "equality," one to seven missile "inferiority"—the three positions are identical. What was identical was the unacceptability of the American casualties that could be inflicted from any of the three. McNamara's statement of this argument at the first meeting of the Ex Comm was summed up in a phrase, "a missile is a missile." "It makes no great difference," he maintained, "whether you were killed by a missile from the Soviet Union or Cuba." The implication was clear. The United States should not initiate a crisis with the Soviet Union, risking a significant probability of nuclear war, over an occurrence that had such small strategic implications.

The perceptions of McGeorge Bundy are difficult to reconstruct. He too seems to have been impressed primarily by the potential in the proposed military actions for escalation to nuclear war, since initially he was the advocate of a diplomatic approach. Several forms of diplomatic approach were outlined, but Bundy argued most persuasively for either confronting Soviet Foreign Minister Gromyko with the evidence and demanding withdrawal, or directly approaching Khrushchev in a similar manner. As he pointed out, this approach would give Khrushchev an opportunity to withdraw the missiles quietly, without humiliation. It